

WHO GETS TO SOUND CREDIBLE? LANGUAGE IDEOLOGIES, AUTHORITY AND ERASURE IN WITNESS FOR THE PROSECUTION AND FORREST GUMP

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ABSTRACT

Revisiting *Witness for the Prosecution* (1957) and *Forrest Gump* (1994), I noticed films have something in common. This essay compares two films to discuss how films make some voices sound credible and others deficient. It uses qualitative close analysis of four scene groups: Christine Helm's cross-examination and later disclosure, and Forrest Gump's evaluation by a school and the Army. Language ideology is the main concept. Language attitudes, institutional authority, iconization, and erasure are used to explain how the evaluations work. In *Witness for the Prosecution*, legal questions and repeated labels allow a barrister to define the witness as a liar. In *Forrest Gump*, the school treats Forrest as below normal, while the Army calls the same person gifted because he obeys orders. Both films suggest credibility and competence are not inherent traits, but contingent products shaped by evaluators, institutional norms and narrative focalization.

Keywords: language ideology; language attitudes; authority; cinematic discourse; erasure

1. INTRODUCTION

Films do more than reproduce ways of speaking. They place accents, forms of address, questions, pauses, and other people's reactions inside a story. These choices invite viewers to hear a character in a particular way. Cinematic discourse therefore has two levels: characters speak to one another, while the film also communicates with its audience through those exchanges [1].

The two films considered here initially seem difficult to compare. *Witness for the Prosecution* is organized around courtroom questioning, whereas *Forrest Gump* presents a personal history in Southern vernacular. Yet both return to the same practical question: who gets to sound believable or capable? I ask how evaluations of speech and institutional interaction construct, and sometimes unsettle, credibility, authority, and social identity. My argument is that these judgments come from social settings rather than from speech alone. The courtroom allows a barrister to organize another person's words.

School and military institutions, meanwhile, give opposite values to Forrest's direct and literal answers.

2. CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK

2.1. Language ideology and attitudes

Language ideology refers to beliefs that connect ways of speaking with social groups, character, and authority. Language attitudes are the more immediate judgments people make about a speaker or variety. A useful distinction is between status or competence and solidarity or social attractiveness [2]. A speaker may sound warm but not competent, or authoritative but distant. Iconization refers to a linguistic feature comes to stand for a whole type of person, and erasure refers to inconvenient differences or inequalities are pushed out of view.

I use these ideas as one framework rather than as separate topics. Language ideology names the broader belief system. Attitudes show the judgment taking place, while authority, iconization, and erasure help explain why the judgment matters. Dong's study of a Beijing school shows how small linguistic differences can become identity markers in institutional evaluation [3]. Wan likewise connects ideas about authentic speech with wider political relations [4].

2.2. Film and institutional talk

Film dialogue should not be separated from the image. Accent and register work together with setting, editing, gaze, costume, and narrative point of view [1]. Especially in a courtroom, a barrister can control the form of a question, and a witness is expected to answer within that form. Work on courtroom interaction shows that repetition, timing, and reformulation can support institutional authority, even when a witness tries to resist [5].

3. DATA AND METHOD

This is a small qualitative empirical case study based on close analysis. It examines observable dialogue and visual details but does not use statistical tests. I selected four scene groups because they contain direct

judgments about truth, intelligence, or competence: Christine's cross-examination, her later explanation of the plan, Forrest's meeting with the school principal, and his exchange with the drill sergeant. Dialogue was checked against the films and available screenplays or transcripts [6]-[9]. For each scene, I ask who evaluates whom, which words and visual cues support the evaluation, what attitude is expressed, and what social consequence follows. I did not use IMDb or Rotten Tomatoes comments as primary data. A reception study would need a reproducible sampling frame, a fixed collection date, and clear coding rules. The narrow scene selection also means that the findings cannot represent every courtroom drama or American film. The advantage is a closer comparison of how particular words, questions, and images work together.

4. ANALYSIS

4.1. Witness: making a witness sound unreliable

Sir Wilfrid's cross-examination of Christine is a clear example of institutional control. Christine says that she 'did not tell the truth,' wording that describes an action and leaves room for context. Wilfrid immediately reformulates it as 'You lied to them.' The shorter verb removes her mitigation and places the answer inside his category. He then repeats 'lie' across different events and limits her to yes-or-no replies. By moving toward 'chronic and habitual liar' and ending with 'Were you lying then, are you lying now?', he turns several actions into a fixed identity. This is iconization: one repeated label comes to stand for the whole person [6].

- (1) Wilfrid: You lied, did you not? Just yes or no.
- (2) Christine: yes.
- (3) Wilfrid: Thank you, and subsequently in arranging the marriage you lied to the authorities.
- (4) Christine: I um did not tell the truth to the authorities.
- (5) Wilfrid: You lied to them.
- (6) Christine: Yes.
- (7) Wilfrid: And in the ceremony of marriage itself when you swore to love and to honor and to cherish your husband that too was a lie?
- (8) Christine: Yes.
- (9)
- (10) Wilfrid: You told them that he was at home with you at 25 minutes past 9 and now you say that was a lie.
- (11) Christine: Yes, a lie.
- (12) Wilfrid: And when you said that he had accidentally cut his wrist again you lied?
- (13) Christine: Yes.
- (14) Wilfrid: And now today you've told us a new story entirely, the question is Frau Helm, Were you lying then, are you lying now? [6].

This scene expresses a negative status attitude: Christine is judged as an unreliable source of knowledge. Wilfrid's status as a barrister gives him more than a loud voice. He can choose the wording, end a topic, and turn toward the jury. The judge allows him broad freedom because the case may involve a murder to Emily French. The jury and spectators hear Christine's short answers, but they hear Wilfrid's longer explanation as the explanation in their mind of what those answers mean. The shift from 'Mrs Vole' to 'Frau Helm,' together with the phrase 'in this country,' also marks her as a German outsider. Credibility is linked with nationality, gender, and marital respectability.

The later disclosure makes the scene less straightforward. Christine explains that she planned the hostile testimony and the false letters because a loving wife's alibi would not be believed. Christine reveals the answer to us that "you said that no jury would believe an alibi given by a loving wife, no matter how much she swore her husband was innocent? That gave me the idea...The idea that I should be a witness, not for my husband, but for the prosecution. That I should swear Leonard was guilty and that you should expose me as a vicious liar because only then would they believe Leonard was innocent." She correctly predicts the court's attitudes. This gives her some discursive control, yet the plan works only when she presents herself as an untrustworthy foreign woman. While she seems to leverage institutional rules to attain agency, such autonomy is grounded in gender and ethnic prejudices; accordingly, she has not liberated herself from the prevailing power structure. The film exposes the court's assumptions, but it also depends on those assumptions for its surprise ending.

4.2. Forrest: competence changes with the institution

Forrest's speech contains features associated with Southern vernacular, including 'momma,' nonstandard agreement, and reduced endings. Other characters often connect these features with low intelligence, but the film does something different. It gives Forrest the voice-over and lets his version of events organize the story. His speech may carry low status for some characters, but it also creates solidarity: viewers are encouraged to hear him as sincere, direct, and morally trustworthy. This gap between competence and solidarity is central to the film's treatment of attitude [2].

The school scene makes the status judgment explicit. The principal calls Forrest 'different,' points to the centre of an IQ chart, and says, 'This is normal.' He then cites the state's minimum score for public school

[8]. The chart and official vocabulary make the decision look neutral. Mrs Gump challenges the category by asking what normal means. The scene shows how a number becomes an identity and then a reason for exclusion.

- (1) Principal: Your boy's... different, Mrs. Gump. Now his IQ is 75.
- (2) Mrs. Gump: Well, we're all different, Mr. Hancock.
- (3) Principal: I want to show you something, Mrs. Gump.
- (4) Principal: Now this is normal. Forrest is right here. The state requires a minimum IQ of 80 to attend public school, Mrs. Gump. He's going to have to go to a special school. And he'll be just fine.
- (5) Mrs. Gump: What does normal mean anyway? He might be... a bit on the slow side. But my boy Forrest is gonna get the same opportunities as everyone else. He's not going to some special school to learn how to retread tires! We're talking about five little points here! There must be something that can be done.[8].



FIG 1: the IQ chart turns ‘normal’ into a visible institutional boundary

The Army gives the same person a different value. When the drill sergeant asks Forrest’s ‘sole purpose,’ Forrest says that he will do whatever he is told. The sergeant immediately calls him a ‘genius’ and ‘gifted’ [8]. The praise is comic, but the institutional contrast is clear. School values standardized intelligence, while the Army values fast obedience. Forrest’s way of speaking has not changed. The activity and evaluator have changed. Drawing on the preceding analysis, we may establish a clearer conclusion: ability itself is not purely objective, but is constructed and defined to serve the requirements of distinct institutional bodies.

- (1) Drill Sergeant: Gump! What's your sole purpose in this army?
- (2) Forrest Gump: To do whatever you tell me, drill sergeant!
- (3) Drill Sergeant: God damn it, Gump! You're a god damn genius! This is the most outstanding answer I have ever heard. You must have a goddamn I.Q. of 160. You are goddamn gifted, Private Gump. Listen up, people...

(4) Forrest Gump: [narrates] Now for some reason I fit in the army like one of them round pegs. It's not really hard. You just make your bed real neat and remember to stand up straight and always answer every question with "Yes, drill sergeant."

- (5) Drill Sergeant: ...Is that clear?
- (6) Forrest Gump: Yes, drill sergeant! [8].

4.3. Comparison the evaluative scenes

Scene	Evaluative cue	Attitude	Effect
Witness: cross-exam	lie; yes/no control	low credibility	Past acts become a fixed identity
Witness: reveal	performed distrust	outsider stereotype	Agency works through stigma
Forrest: school	different; normal; IQ	low competence	Restricted access to public school
Forrest: Army	genius; gifted	high competence	Obedience gains value--

Table 1: How the scenes assign social value to speech

Table 1 brings the scenes together. Wilfrid turns several acts into the stable label ‘liar.’ The principal turns a score into ‘different.’ The drill sergeant turns obedience into ‘genius.’ None of these labels simply describes the speaker. Each label reflects what an institution needs at that moment. The reactions of judges, jurors, charts, uniforms, and synchronized voices make the judgment appear natural.

Forrest’s control of the narration raises a further issue. Racial segregation, war, protest, and the Black Panther Party are filtered through an innocent white male narrator. This may be satire, but it may also create erasure by reducing structural racism and gendered violence to brief episodes in a success story shaped by luck, friendship, and institutional fit.

5. DISCUSSION

The four scenes follow a similar path. An institution first sets a norm, such as truthful testimony, standard intelligence, or obedience. An authorized person then selects a word that can represent the whole speaker. Other people and objects support the judgment. Finally, the label affects who is believed or included. This is the point at which an attitude becomes an ideological consequence. Christine’s label threatens her credibility, while the school label threatens Forrest access to public education. The Army’s positive label gives him a place in that institution, even though it rests on a narrow definition of ability.

There is still room for disagreement about the films. Christine's plan may criticize a legal system that relies on gendered and national stereotypes, but the film also uses those stereotypes for entertainment. Forrest's innocence may criticize official history, but it can also reduce political conflict to background scenery. Keeping both readings matters because ideology is rarely presented as a direct statement. It often appears through humour, sympathy, genre, and decisions about whose story receives the most time.

The two films also show different kinds of resistance. Christine understands the legal system and uses its expectations against it, although she must accept a stigmatized role to do so. Forrest does not deliberately challenge the institutions. His simple compliance reveals their inconsistency by accident. Both films question one hierarchy but leave others in place. Wilfrid remains the main legal interpreter, and Forrest remains the white male voice through which U.S. history is organized. Despite these critiques, neither film fully dismantles dominant power structures. *Witness for the Prosecution* satirizes jury prejudice yet relies on those same harmful national and gender stereotypes to deliver its twist ending for entertainment. *Forrest Gump* meanwhile frames decades of American racial and political conflict as background spectacle filtered through an uncomplicated white male narrator, creating a strong narrative of erasure that dilutes the weight of systemic inequality the film briefly hints at.

The images and sound make the evaluations more convincing. In *Witness*, the courtroom separates the witness box, counsel, judge, jury, and dock. Wilfrid can move, pause, and turn toward the jury. Christine is more fixed in place and answers while everyone watches. The murmuring after the final accusation shows that the audience in the courtroom has accepted a new way of hearing her words. Wilfrid's need for medication adds a useful tension. He is physically weak, but his professional role still gives him control over the exchange. Personal strength and institutional power are not equal.

Forrest Gump uses visual authority in a different way. Forrest's voice-over continues while time, place, and historical events change on screen. This makes a fragmented national history sound like one person's memory. In the school scene, the IQ chart turns the word normal into a visible boundary. In the Army, uniforms, rank, shouting, and group responses make obedience look like order. Without these details, the spoken labels would have less force.

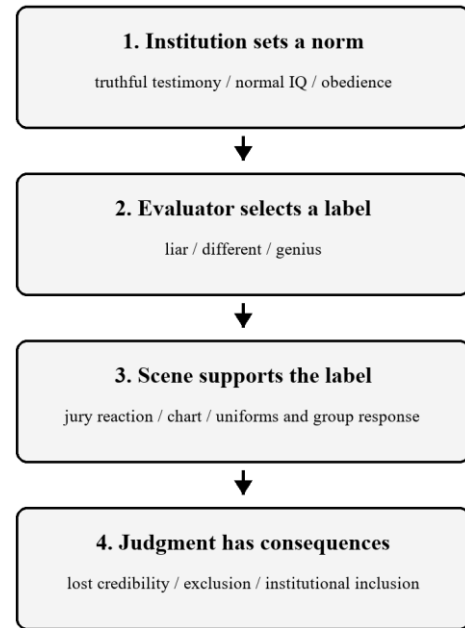


FIG. 2.

FIG 2: From institutional norm to social consequence

6. CONCLUSION

Witness for the Prosecution and *Forrest Gump* tell very different stories, but both show institutions assigning social value to speech. Courtroom questions help portray Christine as a liar. School language places Forrest below normal, while military discourse presents the same person as gifted. The films also show that these judgments can change or be manipulated. Language attitudes matter because they influence who receives credibility, opportunity, and the right to define events. Language ideology, authority, iconization, and erasure keep the analysis connected to wider questions of identity and inequality without losing sight of the dialogue itself.

This reading remains limited by its small, scripted dataset. It describes meanings made available by the films rather than the responses of actual viewers. A later study could add systematically sampled audience reviews, but the present comparison is better treated as a close analysis of how evaluation is built scene by scene.

AI-USE AND ACADEMIC HONESTY NOTE

I used generative AI for preliminary organization of sociolinguistic concepts, grammar checking, translation assistance, and polishing unclear expressions during the writing process. The ideas, research perspectives, scene selections, dialogue analyses, and critical arguments in this paper are my work. I watched and analyzed the films, located and verified relevant scenes and script excerpts, and developed the theoretical interpretations. AI was used to assist in translating and refining my ideas into academic English. I also manually checked sources and revised the final text to ensure that it accurately reflects my own analysis and academic voice.

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